

MY CORNER OF THE WORLD

Sokha's Diary

MY CORNER OF THE WORLD



Sokha's Diary

The Road to the Bell

[AUTHOR NAME]

[PUBLISHER]

© 2026 [AUTHOR NAME]. All rights reserved.

A work of fiction. See “A Note on the Story” at the back of the book for what is invented and what is real.

First edition, 2026. · Story edition

ISBN [ISBN]

CONTENTS

The Ribbon and the Notebook	6
PART ONE · KNOWN ROADS	
1 The First Day	13
2 The Ball in the Grass	19
3 The Bicycle Bell	25
4 The Closed Field	31
PART TWO · THE DETOUR	
5 Maly's Book	37
6 The Noise by the Ditch	43
7 Battambang in a Brochure	49
8 The Shortcut	53
PART THREE · WHAT I DIDN'T ASK	
9 The Blue Plan	61
10 The Slipping Seam	67
11 The Meeting Under the Tree	74
12 The Book of Steps	80
PART FOUR · THE SOUND THAT CARRIES	
13 Measuring	87
14 Sarath's House	95
15 Rain Before the Bell	102
16 The Road to the Bell	110
A Page in Two Voices	120
Words from the Village	125
A Note on the Story	126
About the series	127

PROLOGUE

The Ribbon and the Notebook



Tomorrow is New Year's Day, and a chicken just ate the corner of my first page.

I don't think that's a very good start for a diary.

I was sitting under our house, in the spot where the shade stays cool almost all day. I had my notebook open on my knees. Mae's red hen had been circling me for a while with her head tilted, as if she could read. I looked away for one second. She pecked the paper.

"Hey!"

She ran off with a tiny white triangle in her beak.

Maly laughed so hard she almost dropped her crutch.

"Your story is delicious, Bong."

She was sitting on the bottom step with one leg folded under her. She was trying to tighten the pink ribbon tied around the wood of her crutch, but the knot wouldn't cooperate. I reached out.

“Wait, I’ll do it.”

Maly turned the crutch away from me.

“I can do it.”

She held the end of the ribbon in her teeth, pulled, and retied the knot all by herself. The ribbon was a little dirty and frayed at the ends. Maly thought it was beautiful. She had found it at the market in a pile of fabric scraps, and ever since then, nobody was allowed to say it looked like an old shoelace.



Neak Kru Lina gave us two notebooks before the Khmer New Year holiday, which comes in the middle of April, right when the heat is at its worst. One for me, one for Maly.

“Write down what you don’t want to forget,” she told us.

I didn't understand. If something is important, how could you forget it? Then I tried to remember Papa's voice. I knew it was deep. I knew he sometimes laughed before he got to the end of his own jokes. But the exact sound of it was gone.

So I opened the notebook.

My name is Sokha. I am twelve years old. Mae says my name carries happiness and good health. I'm not sure I carry either one very well. I spill water a lot, I hate getting up early, and last week I stepped in the egg basket.

We live in Chhouk Ksant, in a house on stilts. Down below, there are the chickens, the tools, two water jars, and sometimes the neighbor's pig, who likes our shade better than his own. Up above, there is Mae, Maly, me, and the photo of Papa next to the little altar.

Papa's name was Sopheak. He died on the road when I was eight. In the photo, he is wearing a checkered shirt and smiling as if he knows something the rest of us don't.

Maly is nine. She lost her right leg when she was four. If I ask about it, Mae keeps her words locked behind her teeth. Maly only says that she remembers the sun, a loud noise, and Mae's hands shaking.

I have never asked Maly for more than that.

Well. Not yet.

She opened her own notebook on the step. I caught a glimpse of a line of writing and a drawing that might have been a girl, or a very hungry heron.

"What are you writing?"

Maly shut the notebook.

"Something."

“Can I read it?”

“No.”

“Just one line?”

“No, Sokha.”

When she calls me Sokha instead of Bong, it means the conversation is over.

“Okay. I won’t touch it.”

She studied me to see if my promise was solid.

“Even when I’m not around?”

“Even when you’re not around.”

She slid her notebook under the mat, then patted it twice with the flat of her hand, as if she were closing a door.

Mae came back from the well with news that wiped the smile off Maly’s face.

“Tomorrow morning, we’re going to the wat for the first day of the New Year. Maly, you’ll stay home.”

I knew why. The road was long, the heat climbed fast in the morning, and Maly’s shoulder already hurt from her crutch.

“I can walk,” Maly said.

“I know, Maly,” Mae said. “But not that far, not with all the crowds, and not tomorrow.”

Maly didn’t cry. She picked up the broom and started chasing dust that had done nothing to her.

I watched her.

“Next year, I’ll find a way to take you.”

She stopped sweeping.

“You could start by asking me which way I want.”

Then she went back to her broom.

I wrote my promise in the notebook, right under the spot the hen had pecked. I pressed so hard that the pencil almost went through three pages.

On the step, the pink ribbon tapped softly against the wood of the crutch.

PART ONE

Known Roads



Chapters 1–4

CHAPTER ONE

The First Day

Monday, April 14, 2025



Mae woke me up before the sun did.

In the dark, I thought at first it was raining. It was only the rice she was pouring into a bowl for the offering. The grains made a dry little sound, like bugs tapping against a window.

“Sokha. Up.”

I rolled over to the other side of my mat.

“The New Year can start without me.”

“It already has.”

Maly giggled under her blanket.

Downstairs, Mae had wrapped her krama around her hair. She was wearing her white blouse, the one she keeps folded in a bag so the dust can’t eat it before special occasions. She had packed a small bottle of water, two pieces of rice cake, and the blue offering bowl.

Maly was sitting by the door. She was dressed too.

"I'm coming," she announced.

Mae didn't raise her voice.

"No."

"Uncle Sarath can drop me off on his motorbike."

"And how will you get back? The road will be packed. He'll be helping his own family at the wat. Who will you wait for?"

"I can wait."

"In the sun? With your shoulder?"

Maly squeezed the handle of her crutch.

"Everybody talks about my shoulder like it's the boss of this house."

I stepped in between them, which was not a good idea, but I only figured that out later.

"I can stay with her on the way back."

Mae looked at me.

"You don't even know what time Uncle Sarath will come home."

"We'll figure it out."

"That is exactly what I don't want to hear. 'We'll figure it out' is not a plan."

Maly looked down. The pink ribbon hung perfectly still.

I wanted to keep arguing. I wanted to say that Mae always made the danger bigger than it was, that Maly could decide for herself, that I was old enough to look after her too. But Mae had spent the whole day before sorting rice until dark. Her fingers were still swollen. She had counted the pieces of rice cake before she wrapped them.

I kept my mouth shut.

Before we left, I gave Maly my sharpest pencil.

“I’ll bring you back everything.”

“Everything like what?”

“The stories. The sounds. What people do.”

“I don’t only want stories.”

“I know.”

She took the pencil anyway.

The sky was starting to go pale when Mae and I left the house. The road still held the cool of the night. We walked where the dirt was packed hard, between motorbike tracks and sandal prints. Mae never stepped off the part of the path everybody used, not even when a puddle made us slow down.

Other families joined us along the way. A little girl carried a tray of fruit wider than her shoulders. Two boys wore matching shirts and were already arguing about which of them looked better. Somewhere near the wat, a loud-speaker crackled.

At the entrance, flags moved in the morning air. Someone had swept the courtyard. Under a tree, some teenagers were getting a rope ready for the afternoon games. Little kids ran circles around them until an old man threatened to tie them up with it.

Mae handed me the blue bowl.

“Hold it straight.”

“I am holding it straight.”

“The rice is falling out.”

I straightened it. Three grains of rice were sitting on my sandal.

We went inside with everyone else. The incense stung my eyes a little. The monks’ voices rose and fell together. I

didn't understand every word, but the chanting filled the room the way water fills a jar. Mae set our rice down with the other offerings. Next to it, someone had left a basket of mangoes and some crisp new bills. Our bowl looked very small.

Mae looked at it without shame.

A monk sprinkled the crowd with scented water. A few drops landed on my forehead. They smelled like jasmine. Mae pressed her palms together. Her lips moved.

I knew she was asking for us to be safe. That's what she always asks for.

I thought about Maly sitting on the step with my pencil. I asked for her to be here next year. Then I remembered what she had said, and I added, inside my head: if she still wants to come.

On the way out, Mae stopped at the little shrine to the Neak Ta, under a tree with split bark. She left a little water and a few grains of rice.

"Protect my children's roads," she whispered.

The word roads followed me around for the rest of the morning.

I tried to remember everything for Maly: the boy who got so much powder thrown on his face that he looked like a ghost; the old lady who won at tug of war against three teenagers; the loudspeaker that swallowed half the words; the smell of grilled bananas; the way Mae laughed when a drop of water ran down the back of her neck.

I hadn't seen that laugh in a long time.

On the walk home, she handed me a piece of rice cake.

"This one is for Maly."

“I know.”

“Then why did you already take a bite?”

I looked at the missing corner.

“To check if it was good.”

Mae shook her head, but she was still smiling.

Maly was waiting for us under the house. She had been writing on a piece of wrapping paper next to her. I gave her the rice cake with my thumb over the bitten part.

She noticed right away.

“The festival ate my piece?”

“Just a very small festival.”

I told her about the powder ghost, the old lady, the games, the jasmine water, and Mae’s laugh. She listened while she ate. When I was finished, she wiped her fingers on her pants and handed me the wrapping paper.

She had drawn a line with six little circles on it.

“What’s that?”

“The road to the wat.”

“You don’t even know it.”

“You do. How many breaks would I need?”

I looked at Mae. She was washing the blue bowl with her back to us.

“I don’t know.”

“Then ask. Watch. Count. You said you’d find a way.”

She pushed my notebook toward me.

We sat down in the dirt. I drew the house, the well, the big tamarind tree, the bend where the ground turns rocky, and then the wat. Maly added circles where she thought she might be able to stop and rest.

“Is there shade here?”

“In the morning, yes.”

“What about here?”

“A mean buffalo.”

“That is not a good spot for a break.”

She crossed out my circle.

That night, the neighbors turned their music up too loud again. Mae made num banh chok. The three of us ate under the house while kids by the well were still splashing each other.

Maly set our map down next to her bowl.

“Next year,” she said, “I don’t want you to just tell me about the places.”

She tapped her finger on the line.

“I want to go.”

CHAPTER TWO

The Ball in the Grass

Tuesday, April 15, 2025



Vannak has five rules for soccer.

Rule one: the flat stones are the goals.

Rule two: nobody moves the goals when their team is losing.

Rule three: a little kid counts the same as a big kid, unless he sits down in the middle of the field to eat a mango.

Rule four: whoever kicks the ball into the chickens has to go get it.

Rule five: if the ball leaves the ground everybody knows, it doesn't exist anymore.

I thought he made up the last one just to annoy me.

We were playing on the field behind the well, between the last houses and the rice paddies. The New Year games were still going on all over the village. We could hear the rope snapping in the hands of the tug of war teams, a drum,

people laughing, and a lady selling drinks who swore hers were the coldest in the whole district.

Maly had come with Mae. The field was only one break away from our house. They sat in the shade near some other women. Maly had set her crutch down beside her and was keeping score in my notebook. She was clearly rooting for Vannak's team, even though I'm her brother.

"Two to one!" she yelled.

"You forgot my goal."

"You missed."

"I almost didn't miss."

"A miss is a miss."

Vannak gave her a thumbs up.

So I had to score to save my honor.

Our ball had lost almost all its air. It only bounced when it felt like it. I got it near one of the stones, dodged past Vannak, and kicked as hard as I could.

The ball missed the goal.

It rolled right off the edge of the field, across the dirt, and stopped in the tall grass.

Everyone froze.



The ball was only a few steps away. Not far at all. We could still see half of its brown skin between the stems.

Rithy, the fastest player on our team, stepped forward.

“I’ll get it.”

Vannak shouted, “Stop!”

Rithy stopped with one foot in the air.

“What?”

“You stay on the field.”

“The ball is right there.”

“It’s not on the ground where everybody plays anymore.”

Rithy laughed.

“You’re scared of grass now?”

Everyone started talking at once. We only had one other ball, and it was even flatter. The last game of the day was supposed to start soon. Rithy took a step to the side.

Vannak said it again.

“Stop.”

His voice had changed. It wasn't the voice of a boy arguing about a goal anymore. It was hard, almost like a grown man's.

Rithy looked at me.

“You kicked it. You go get it.”

I saw Maly sit up straight under the tree. Mae wasn't watching yet. She was talking to a neighbor.

A few steps.

I could reach the ball, bring it back, and show everybody I wasn't scared. I could also hear Vannak's fifth rule: if the ball leaves the ground everybody knows, it doesn't exist anymore.

“We'll use the other one,” I said.

Rithy blew out a big, loud breath.

“The baby and the king of the babies.”

He pointed at me, then at Vannak.

My face got hot. I wanted to call him something terrible. Instead, I went and got the flat ball from under the tree. Maly handed it to me.

“Two to one,” she reminded me.

“Thanks for your support.”

“I'm a fair referee.”

We lost four to one. The replacement ball rolled like a square pumpkin. Every time we let in a goal, Rithy pointed at me as if it were all my fault.

After the game, I sat under the big tamarind tree. I had dirt in my ears and a bad mood big enough to fill the whole courtyard.

Vannak came over with two cups of water.

“You did the right thing.”

“We lost.”

“That’s not the same thing.”

“Rithy’s going to call me a baby until the next rainy season.”

“Rithy calls his own brother a baby. His brother is seventeen.”

He handed me a cup.

We drank without talking. Vannak kept turning his cup around in his hands.

“My father lost his arm because he wanted to save time,” he said.

I sort of knew that already, without really knowing it. In our village, adults use the word accident to close a story.

“He was going to collect firewood. He knew that forest. He stepped off the path for a few meters. After that, all he remembers is the noise.”

Vannak kept his eyes on his cup.

“Ever since then, he tells me the same things. Don’t go near it. Don’t touch anything. Tell an adult. And if anyone calls you a coward, let him talk with his mouth while you walk home on both of your legs.”

I thought about Maly. I looked over at the tree. She was laughing with a little girl, her head thrown back. Her pink ribbon swung against her crutch.

“Does your father want you to be a deminer?”

“No. He wants me to sell phones in a store with air conditioning.”

“And you?”

"I want to work with the teams that make the land safe."

"Is he okay with that?"

"Not at all."

Vannak smiled for the first time.

"We argue about it every Sunday. It's a family tradition."

On the way home, we told Uncle Sarath about the ball. He told the village chief. Nobody went to get it. The field got a few steps smaller until a special team could come and check the edge.

Rithy kept saying we were scared.

Maly told him, "And you're scared of a flat ball."

He didn't have an answer for that.

Tonight, I made a list.

WHAT THE BALL COST ME

1. *One game.*
2. *Some skin off my knee.*
3. *About a hundred jokes from Rithy.*

WHAT I GOT TO KEEP

1. *My feet on the ground everybody knows.*
2. *Vannak trusting me.*
3. *A brother who is seventeen and, somewhere, still gets called a baby.*

All night, I could still hear Rithy laughing.

I didn't miss the ball.

CHAPTER THREE

The Bicycle Bell

Wednesday, April 16, 2025



You can hear Neak Kru Lina's motorbike before you can see it.

It coughs on the curve, goes quiet for a second, and then starts up again sounding like a pot falling down the stairs. Every kid in the village knows that sound. We ran to the road before the red Honda even came out of the dust.

Lina had tied two mats, a box of chalk, and a gigantic bag behind her. It looked like her motorbike was moving house.

"Neak Kru!"

"Careful!" she shouted. "If you knock me over, school starts at the hospital."

She parked in front of the empty house that Lok Ta Ming's family was lending us. The classroom was upstairs. The house was near the wat; Sarath's was farther on, behind it. The staircase had four steps, and one of them was taller than the others.

Maly got there with Mae a few minutes later. She had insisted on carrying her own notebook in a little bag. At the first step, she took her time. A boy behind her tried to get past.

"You can wait," I told him.

"I'm going to be late."

"The teacher is still untying the mats."

Maly pulled herself up onto the last step and gave me a look.

"I didn't need you to start a fight."

"He was pushing you."

"You could have asked him to back up without talking like I'm a fragile sack of rice."

I didn't say anything. Class hadn't even started, and I was already wrong.

Inside, fifteen kids were trying to find a place to sit. The little ones wanted to be in front. The big ones wanted the wall so they could lean on it. A chicken had followed somebody up the stairs and was strolling across the mat like it was enrolled.

The only open spot left for Maly was outside, by the door.

"She can sit there," a boy suggested. "She'll still be able to hear."

I was about to answer when Maly set down her bag.

"No. Move the mat a little closer to the board."

Nobody moved.

"If everybody scoots forward one hand's length, there will be a spot right here."

She pointed to the corner next to me.

Neak Kru Lina looked around the room.

“Maly is right. One hand each.”

We pulled the mat forward. The little kids complained. The chicken complained louder than anyone and flapped off toward the door.

Maly sat down inside.

The only thing she asked me to help with was leaning her crutch against the wall. I did it without saying a word. It was surprisingly hard.



Neak Kru Lina wrote the date on the board.

“Does anyone know what day it is?”

Three kids shouted Monday, two shouted Friday, and one little one suggested noodle day.

“Wednesday,” Maly said.

“Thank you, Maly. The last day of the New Year. And the first day of our new term.”

We started by writing our names. The little kids copied the letters. Vannak wrote his as slowly as a buffalo crossing a rice paddy. I wrote my name too fast, and one of the letters looked like a broken chair.

Maly stuck out her tongue while she concentrated. She wrote her name as if every letter had to be able to stand up on its own.

At break time, Lina looked at Maly's notebook.

“Are you working on a story?”

Maly covered the page with her arm.

“Yes.”

“Maybe you'll read it to us someday.”

“Maybe.”

Then Maly added, “On the day we get a real classroom of our own.”

Lina went quiet for a moment.

“Actually, I need to talk to you about this house.”

She explained that Lok Ta Ming's family was moving back to the village. The family would need the room soon. We could stay until May 7, and no longer.

All the kids started talking at once.

“Are we going to stop again?”

“Where will we have class?”

“Under the tree?”

“What about when it rains?”

Neak Kru Lina held up both hands.

“I don't know yet.”

It was the first time I had ever heard her say that. Adults usually like to answer later, or say we'll see, which sometimes means never.

"I'm working on it with the village chief and the families," she went on. "My organization can keep class going three days a week for now. But we need a place."

Maly closed her notebook.

"Then find it before my story is finished."

Lina laughed.

"I'll do my best."

Before the last lesson, she took something out of her bag. A little bicycle bell, round, with a scratch on one side.

"This isn't a temple bell," she said. "It isn't even a school bell. But if everybody is quiet, it works just fine."

She pressed the lever.

Ding ding.

The sound was thin, almost funny. But the whole room went quiet anyway. Even the little kids looked up.

"When it rings, class starts. When it rings again, class is over. And as long as we can hear it, it means school exists somewhere."

Vannak raised his hand.

"If we change houses, do we keep the bell?"

"Of course."

"What if we have class under the tree?"

"Then it goes in the tree."

"What if we can't find anywhere?"

Lina looked at the little bell in her hand.

"Then we keep looking."

She rang the end of class.

On the way home, Maly walked slowly. Mae carried her bag, with Maly's permission. I carried the little bell, because Lina had asked me to bring it back for the next class. Her bag was already too full.

I rang it once.

"Stop," Maly said. "You're going to wear out the sound."

"Sounds don't wear out."

"You don't know that."

At home, she sat by the window and opened her notebook. I tried to look without looking like I was looking.

She wrote a title, then put her hand over it.

"I promised," I said.

"I'm just checking if your promise still works."

She blew on the ink.

"On the day the new classroom opens, I'm going to read this page. And I'm going to ring the bell."

"Even if it's a bicycle bell?"

"Especially if it's that one."

She closed her notebook.

CHAPTER FOUR

The Closed Field

Friday, April 18, 2025



The red rope stretched across the path like a sentence nobody was allowed to finish.

I saw it on the way home from school with Vannak. Two stakes had been pounded into the ground on either side of a farm path. Between them, a red-and-white rope trembled in the hot air. A sign told us to keep away.

That path led to several fields and eventually joined the road to the wat. Adults had used it for a long time. That day, nobody was on it.

Three boys were already standing in front of the rope. Rithy was one of them.

“People say they found something near the ditch,” he whispered.

“Who says?” Vannak asked.

“My cousin.”

“Your cousin also says he can outrun a buffalo.”

Rithy ignored him. He bent down to look under the rope.

"You can't see anything from here."

"That's the whole point," Vannak said. "You don't go any closer."

One of the little kids was about to step off the trail.

Vannak didn't run to grab him. He called Uncle Sarath, who was fixing a roof a few houses away.

"Uncle Sarath! The little kids are going near the rope!"

Sarath came down his ladder so fast he left his hammer on the roof. He led the kids back along the path everybody used, then sent all of us back toward the village.

"There's nothing for you to see over there."

"What did they find?" I asked.

"Something that trained people need to look at. That's all you need to know."

That was not nearly all I needed to know.

At the wat, a man I had never seen before was waiting with the village chief. His name was Kosal. He worked with a team whose job was to teach communities about safety. The families had been called in for a short meeting.

Mr. Kosal didn't bring any objects, or any pictures that would make you want to go take a look. He said the words the adults in our village usually avoid: land mines, explosives, leftovers from old wars. They can stay hidden in the ground for dozens of years, and nobody can tell just by looking where they are. He explained that the strip near the ditch had never been checked and that it would stay closed. If we ever saw a rope, a sign, or a place where nobody was allowed to go, we had to stay far away, touch nothing, and tell an adult.

A boy asked, "But what if my ball is in there?"

Everybody looked at Rithy.

Mr. Kosal answered, "A ball can be replaced."

Vannak nudged me with his elbow. I didn't need him to remind me about our game.

When we got home, Mae was waiting for us under the house. She had already heard about the closed path. In a village, bad news travels faster than motorbikes.

"You didn't go near the rope?"

"No, Mae."

"You didn't pick anything up?"

"No."

She put both hands on my shoulders and looked at me as if she were searching my face for any trace of a lie.

Maly was sitting behind her. She didn't say anything.

"Is it because of what happened to her?" I asked.

Mae took her hands away.

The neighbor's pig walked right between us with a banana leaf in its mouth. Nobody laughed.

"Come inside," Mae said.

We sat upstairs. The heat was trapped under the roof. Mae poured water into three cups, but she didn't drink.

"Maly was four," she began. "I had to bring lunch to some workers. Other families used a path near some empty land. I thought..."

Her voice stopped.

Maly set down her cup.

"You can say you didn't know, Mae."

Mae closed her eyes.

"I didn't know."

She told us only what she could. The path had never been officially checked. It looked like any other path. Maly had run a few steps ahead of her. There was a noise. After that, what Mae remembered most was screaming until she couldn't feel her throat.

I looked at Maly.

"Do you remember?"

She shrugged one shoulder.

"The ground was hot. I had lost a sandal. After that, I remember Mae's hands. They were shaking so hard she couldn't give me any water."

Mae lowered her head.

"It wasn't your fault," Maly said.

"I was your mother."

"You still are."

For a few seconds, the only sound was a chicken scratching the dirt under the house. Mae stared at the water in her cup without drinking it.

I asked, "Why didn't anybody ever tell me?"

Maly turned toward me.

"Because it's my story too."

"I know."

"No. You always look at Mae when you ask questions about me."

She wasn't angry. It was worse than that. She was exactly right.

"If you want to know something about me, ask me."

My ears got hot.

"Okay."

"And if I say no, it means no."

“Okay.”

Mae finally took a sip of water.

That evening, she lit incense in front of Papa’s photo. I didn’t understand all of her prayer. I recognized our names, the word road, and the word home. She said Maly’s name twice.

In my notebook, I tried to draw the red rope. My pencil made it gray.

So I wrote underneath it:

*A line can look thin and still be stronger
than a wall.*

I read it again. It sounded like something Neak Kru Lina would say. I crossed it out.

Instead, I wrote:

*The rope moved in the wind. Nobody crossed
it.*

PART TWO

The Detour



Chapters 5–8

CHAPTER FIVE

Maly's Book

Saturday, April 19, 2025



Maly's notebook was open. She had left it on the mat by the window before going down to help Mae turn over the rice drying on a tarp. A page was flapping in the breeze. All I had to do was reach out.

I was sweeping the room. Well, I was supposed to be sweeping the room. For almost a whole minute, the broom hadn't touched the floor.

Three days ago, I had promised again not to read it without permission.

Three days is a long time for a promise.

I moved closer.

Maly's handwriting was big and slanted downhill. At the top of the page, she had drawn a girl in a skirt with a crutch and something above her head. Maybe a bird. Maybe a cloud.

I could read it without touching it. That wasn't really disobeying.

I put down the broom.

Downstairs, Mae called out.

"Sokha! The chicken is in the rice!"

I jumped as if the notebook had yelled at me.

I ran down the stairs. The red hen was pecking right in the middle of the tarp. Maly was trying to shoo her away with a basket. The hen dodged every swing and looked offended the whole time.

"She likes stories and rice," I said. "She's very educated."

"Help me instead of talking."

We surrounded the hen. She ran out between my legs, knocked over the basket, and hid under the house.

Mae looked at us.

"Two children, one chicken. The chicken wins."

Maly was still laughing when she went back upstairs. Then she saw her notebook lying open with the broom next to it.

Her laugh disappeared.

"Did you read it?"

"No."

That was almost true. I had seen the drawing and a few letters, but not one whole sentence.

"Did you touch it?"

"No."

She checked how the notebook was lying, like a detective. I stayed by the door.

"I wanted to," I added.

Maly looked up.

"But you didn't?"

"No."

"Why not?"

"Because I promised."

She closed the notebook. I couldn't tell if I had done something right, or just managed not to do something wrong.

Later, while Mae was putting the rice away, Maly came and sat with me under the house.

"I'm going to read you a little bit."

"You don't have to."

"I know."

She opened to the page I had almost read and followed the words with her finger.

"The girl wanted to get to school on the day they hung up the bell. She didn't know how yet, but she knew she would be there."

Maly closed the notebook.

"That's all."

"Is the girl you?"

"She's a girl."

"With a pink ribbon?"

"Maybe."

"And a crutch?"

"Lots of girls have crutches, Sokha."

She was trying to keep a straight face, but the corner of her mouth kept twitching.

"Do you really want to read your story when the classroom opens?"

"Yes."

"Even if the new room is far away?"

"Yes."

"Even if..."

"You ask too many questions."

She turned my notebook toward her.

"Just write that you'll be there."

I wrote:

*When the new classroom opens, I will help
Maly get there and I will listen to her read.*

She read it over.

"'I will help.' What does that mean?"

"I don't know yet."

"Good. Then don't add anything."

She signed Maly under my sentence, with my pencil.

In the afternoon, we went to the market with Mae. She had a basket of eggplants, some bunches of herbs, and three little pumpkins to sell. Uncle Sarath lent us his motorbike. Mae drove, Maly sat between us, and I held the basket in the back.

Every time we hit a bump, a pumpkin tried to escape.

The market was full of voices and engines and smells that shoved each other out of the way. Mae spread the vegetables on a piece of tarp. Maly was in charge of the money. I weighed the eggplants and only got it wrong one time out of three.

A woman picked up a bunch of herbs.

"Fifteen hundred," I announced.

"One thousand," she said.

"Fourteen hundred."

"One thousand."

“Thirteen hundred.”

“One thousand.”

I looked at Mae.

“This lady doesn’t know how to bargain.”

The lady smiled. Mae sold it to her for twelve hundred.

At the end of the day, Mae counted the riels on her knee, where nobody could see.

MARKET MONEY

- *Vegetables sold: 48,000 riels*
- *Rice: 14,000*
- *Dried fish: 7,000*
- *Oil: 5,000*
- *Gas for Uncle Sarath: 5,000*
- *Money Mae put aside without telling us why: 4,000*
- *Left over: 13,000*

It wasn’t much.

Mae took us to the school supplies stand.

“One thing each. No more.”

Maly picked a pink eraser shaped like a heart. She already had one almost exactly like it, worn down to the size of a fingernail.

“You could get a pencil,” I said.

“You could pick your own thing and let me pick mine.”

I picked a blue pen. The cap fit tight. When I tried it on a scrap of cardboard, the ink came out on the first try without scratching.

Mae paid. Then she looked at the bills she had left and took us to eat three small bowls of kuy teav on little

red stools.

“We could save the money,” I said.

“We could also eat at the market once in a while.”

Maly blew on her noodles so seriously you would have thought she was putting out a fire.

On the ride home, she rubbed her shoulder several times. Sitting behind her, I could see her hand reaching under her sleeve. She kept quietly shifting her crutch, which was strapped against her leg.

At home, I asked her, “Does it hurt?”

“A little.”

“Since when?”

“Since always. More when I walk a long way.”

I wanted to look at the wooden part that pressed under her arm. She moved the crutch away.

“You can look. Don’t touch.”

The wood was smooth but hard. The skin under her sleeve had a red mark on it.

“We should do something.”

“Maybe.”

“I could...”

Maly held up one finger.

“You wrote a promise this morning.”

I went and got my notebook. With the blue pen, I traced over the sentence we had signed.

The ink almost went through the paper.

CHAPTER SIX

The Noise by the Ditch

Monday, April 21, 2025



My blue pen exploded on my finger right when the noise happened.

It didn't really explode. The cap on the end came off because I was chewing it, and a big blot of ink spread over my pointer finger.

But the noise was real.

It came from far away and close by at the same time. A deep boom that made the floor shake under our knees. All the birds lifted out of the trees at once.

Neak Kru Lina was writing the words from our dictation on the board for us to correct. She stopped in the middle of the word river.

Nobody said anything.

Then a dog started barking. People were shouting near the houses.

Lina put down the chalk.

“You stay here.”

Vannak stood up.

“Neak Kru...”

“Sit down, Vannak. Nobody goes to the window. Nobody goes downstairs.”

She closed the shutters on the side facing the ditch and counted us out loud. Fifteen. Then fifteen again.

A little boy named Chhun started to cry.

“What was that?”

I didn’t know. I wiped my finger on my pants and sat down next to him.

“Maybe a tire,” I said.

Vannak gave me a look. It was a weak lie. A tire had never made a whole village go quiet like that.

Chhun grabbed my sleeve.

“My father works over there.”

“Neak Kru will find out.”

From the doorway, Lina called to the adult in the house next door without sending any students outside. Then she had us move back against the far wall. Her voice stayed calm, but she was gripping the little bell so hard her knuckles had turned white.



We waited.

Time started moving very slowly. A fly circled the board. The ink dried on my skin. Outside, a motorbike left, then another one.

Finally, Uncle Sarath came up the stairs. There was dust on his face.

“It’s Lok Ta Bun,” he told Lina. “Near the ditch. The adults are taking care of him. A special team has been called.”

Lina asked, “Is he alive?”

Sarath nodded, just once.

Nobody asked how badly he was hurt. Chhun let go of my sleeve, but nobody moved.

Class stopped. Families came to pick up their kids in little groups. Mae came with Maly, who had stayed home

that morning because her shoulder hurt too much. She had left her work right in the middle. She took my face in her hands, checked my arms, my legs, then did the same thing to Maly, even though Maly had been right beside her the whole way there.

“Mae, we’re fine,” I said.

“I can see that.”

But her hands kept checking.

After the accident, the closure was extended to the whole path along the ditch, as far as the road to school. It was the shortest way between our side of the village and the houses behind the wat. Several of the buildings that could have held the school were over there.

We had to go home the long way around.

At first, Maly walked fast, as if she wanted to prove something to the road. The dust was soft under her one sandal. After the first bend, her breathing changed. After the tamarind tree, she stopped.

“Break,” she said.

Mae reached for her bag.

“I’ll keep it.”

“It’s heavy.”

“I said break, not take everything I have.”

We sat in the shade. Nobody talked about the accident. The whole village seemed to be listening to the motorbikes that had left for the health center.

Maly started walking again. She stopped two more times. The third time, she slipped her hand under her sleeve and rubbed her shoulder.

“Give me your bag,” I said.

“Ask better.”

I took a breath.

“Do you want me to carry your bag home?”

“Yes.”

I took it. It weighed less than I had imagined.

That evening, Lok Ta Bun’s wife sent a message to the village chief’s phone. Her husband had been moved to a hospital. He was going to live. His leg was badly hurt, and the doctors were talking about a long recovery.

Mae packed a bag of rice for his family. She added two cans of fish that we had been saving for the days when the market didn’t bring in much.

“They’ll need a lot more than this,” she said.

“When is he coming back?” Maly asked.

“I don’t know.”

“Will he be able to work again?”

“I don’t know.”

Mae tied the bag shut and set it by the door.

That night, nobody in the neighborhood played music. Even the dogs seemed to bark more quietly.

Maly and I were lying down when I asked her, “Are you scared?”

“Yes.”

“Of what?”

“That the path stays closed. That the school moves to the other side. That everybody says it’s too complicated for me.”

I had only been thinking about the noise, about Lok Ta Bun, and about old things hidden in the ground. Maly was already thinking about the day after.

“We’ll figure it out,” I said.

She turned her head toward me in the dark.

“Mae said that’s not a plan.”

The next day, we walked part of the long way around again so we could time it. Halfway, Maly sat down on a flat rock. Her shoulder was red.

She looked at the road stretching ahead of us.

“If the school ends up over there, I won’t make it like this.”

On my finger, the blue stain wouldn’t wash off.

CHAPTER SEVEN

Battambang in a Brochure

Wednesday, April 23, 2025



Neak Kru Lina gave me the brochure after class. She had asked me to stay behind while everyone else went downstairs. Maly was already outside with Mae. I thought Lina had figured out that I was drawing chickens in the margins of my dictation.

“I wanted to talk to you about the walk to school,” she said.

“Did Maly tell you?”

“She told me the long way hurts her. I should have asked her before I announced we’d be looking for a room on the other side.”

Lina took a folded sheet of paper out of her bag. On the front, a child was walking between two bars in a bright room. Underneath was the address of the regional rehabilitation center in Battambang and a phone number.

“Their services are free,” Lina said. “A team also holds assessment days in different areas. There’s going to be one

at the health center on May 3.”

“Are they going to give Maly a new leg?”

“I don’t know.”

I didn’t like that answer.

“But they make artificial legs.”

“Yes. They also adjust things, give out walking aids, and follow kids as they grow. A specialist has to talk to Maly, see what works for her, and explain the options. I don’t get to decide. And neither do you.”

She said the last part without being mean about it. That didn’t make it any nicer to hear.

“Do you have to go to Battambang?”

“For some of it, yes. The assessment on May 3 could be a start. After that, there might be several appointments.”

I thought about Mae in the fields, her vegetables at the market, the bills she had slipped into her pocket.

“If it’s free, why doesn’t everybody go?”

Lina folded the brochure the other way.

“Because the trip takes time. Because a parent sometimes has to lose a day of work. Because you have to go back for adjustments. Because families don’t always hear about it. Free doesn’t mean easy.”

She handed me the paper.

“Show it to Mae and Maly.”

I tucked it inside my notebook.

On the way home, I didn’t say anything.

Mae walked in front with an empty basket on her hip. She had spent the morning fixing the little dirt walls around a rice field. Dried mud covered her calves. Maly walked next to me and stopped at the spots we had marked.

“What did Neak Kru want?” she asked.

“Nothing. My handwriting.”

The lie came out easily. That’s what worried me.

At home, Mae got a call on Uncle Sarath’s phone. Lok Ta Bun’s family wanted to know if someone could water his little vegetable garden while he was gone. Mae promised to go the next day before her own work.

She hung up and sat down on the step for a second.

“Are you tired?” I asked.

“No.”

That was her lie. It came out easily too.

I almost gave her the brochure. Then Maly asked if there was any rice left. Mae got up. She counted what was left in the jar and talked about the market, the oil, and the gas money we owed Sarath.

I kept the paper in my notebook.

Maly came and sat next to me to ask for the blue pen. I shut the notebook so fast that a corner of the brochure stuck out.

“What are you hiding?”

“Nothing.”

“Your nothing has a white corner.”

I pushed the paper back between the pages.

“It’s information for school.”

“Then why are you sitting on it?”

I stood up too fast. The notebook fell flat without opening. Maly didn’t try to grab it. She just held out her hand.

“I wanted the pen.”

I gave it to her.

“You can keep your nothing,” she said.

She gave the pen back to me before dinner, with the cap on tight.

That night, I read the brochure again under the lamp. There were words I didn't know. Adjustment. Assessment. Checkups. I copied them out with my blue pen.

I did a different kind of math than usual.

WHAT SOMETHING FREE MIGHT COST

- *A day when Mae doesn't work.*
- *The ride to the health center.*
- *Maybe another trip all the way to Battambang.*
- *A market day lost.*
- *Meals away from home.*
- *Starting over when Maly grows.*

At the bottom of the brochure, a little drawing showed a soft pad wrapped around a support. It didn't look complicated. Some cloth. Something soft. A few ties.

Maybe I could do that.

Not a new leg. Not a machine. Just something that would keep the wood from hurting Maly's shoulder on the long way around.

I drew a cover in my notebook. Front view. Side view. I circled the word appointment three times, and then I hid the brochure under my sleeping mat.

At the top of a fresh page, I wrote:

What I Can Do Without Bothering Anyone

The page stayed empty for a long time.

CHAPTER EIGHT

The Shortcut

Friday, April 25, 2025



We left late because of a lid.

The lid of the big water jar had fallen off during the night. A chicken had managed to perch on the edge and had left something in the water that I am not going to describe. Mae had to empty the jar, scrub it, and fetch clean water. I went to the well with her. Maly got our notebooks ready.

By the time we finally left for school, the sun was already high.

“Writing is the first lesson,” Maly said.

“We’ll walk fast.”

“You will, maybe.”

I grabbed her bag before asking. She kept her hand on it. I let go.

“Do you want me to carry it?”

“Yes. Thank you.”

We reached the fork where the long way begins. To the left, the approved road ran past the well, went around several fields, and came back behind the wat. To the right, the short path cut across near the ditch.

The rope was still there.

Nobody was guarding it. No adult. No vehicle. Just the stakes, the rope, and the empty dust behind them.

Far away, very far away, the little bell rang.

Ding ding.

Maly closed her eyes.

"They're starting."

"If we take the long way, we'll get there in time for the end."

"I know how to count."

She was staring at the closed path.

"You can see motorbike tracks."

"They're old."

"I didn't say we should go that way. I'm saying I'm tired of a rope deciding everything."

"It's not the rope. It's what's behind it."

"We don't even know what's behind it."

"Exactly."

I said it too loud. Maly tightened her grip on her crutch.

We stood at the fork while class went on without us.

I thought about my promise in the notebook. I will help Maly get there. The short path would save us enough time. The rope was thin. The ground looked exactly like the ground we were standing on.

Then I saw the ball in the grass again. I heard Mr. Kosal: a ball can be replaced. So can a lesson, maybe. A sister can't.



"We're taking the long way," I said.

Maly didn't answer.

We walked. She went fast at first, then slower. At the first break, she didn't talk. At the second break, she took her bag back from me.

"I can carry it."

"I know."

"Then stop looking at me like that."

"Like what?"

"Like every step is a test I might fail."

We started walking again.

By the time the schoolhouse came into view, the kids were already coming down the stairs. Lina had the bell in one hand and a stack of papers in the other.

"Maly! Sokha! What happened?"

"The water jar," I answered.

Maly looked at me like I was the dumbest kid in all of Banteay Meanchey.

"The road," she said. "The road happened."

Neak Kru Lina told us they had started preparing the pieces the kids would read at the opening of the new classroom. The village chief had called a meeting for Monday. Uncle Sarath was thinking about offering a house that belonged to his family, behind the wat.

On the other side of the long way around.

Lina handed Maly a sheet of paper that several kids had already written on. Each person had to add one sentence to the story the person before them had started. Vannak's handwriting climbed all the way up into the margin. Rithy's was so tiny it looked like an ant trail.

Maly followed the lines with her finger.

“Did they read their sentences out loud?”

“Yes,” Lina said.

“And did everybody laugh when Vannak spelled crocodile with three extra letters?”

“Only two.”

“I wanted to be here to hear it.”

“I can tell you about it,” I offered.

Maly looked up at me.

“You were late too.”

That was true. The walk hadn’t hurt my shoulder, but it had stolen the same lesson from me.

“I can give you the assignment now,” Lina offered.

Maly held her notebook tight.

“It’s not the same.”

She went back down the stairs.

I followed her to the shade of a mango tree.

“Maly, I couldn’t cross that rope.”

“I didn’t ask you to cross it.”

“Then why are you mad?”

“Because you always say no, and then you think you’re done helping.”

“I protected you.”

She thumped her crutch against the ground.

“There. That’s exactly it.”

“What?”

“You want to be the one who protects me. You don’t want to be the one who asks, okay, so now how do we do this?”

I didn’t have an answer.

Maly started for home without waiting for me. Neak Kru Lina put a hand on my shoulder.

“She’s angry at the situation as much as she’s angry at you.”

“That doesn’t change anything.”

“No, it doesn’t.”

I walked home behind Maly, far enough back that she wouldn’t think I was watching her, close enough that she would know I was there.

That night, I took out the brochure and my drawing of the cover.

I couldn’t open the shortcut. I couldn’t move the school. I couldn’t drive Mae and Maly to Battambang.

But maybe I could make the long way hurt less.

I wrote a new heading in blue ink:

The Plan

PART THREE

What I Didn't Ask



Chapters 9–12

CHAPTER NINE

The Blue Plan

Saturday, April 26, 2025



My drawing was better than my idea.

On paper, the cover wrapped perfectly around the top of the crutch. I had added arrows, measurements, and even a little side view. It looked like the plan of somebody who knew what he was doing.

That somebody was not me.

I needed clean cloth, something soft, and a way to hold everything in place without touching the wood. I had decided not to cut, nail, or glue anything. The cover had to come off. In my mind, that proved I was being careful.

I still wasn't planning to ask Maly.

After breakfast, I went to Aunt Sophea's house. She was sewing by her window with one foot on the pedal and a yellow shirt in her hands. Her machine went tak tak tak, steadier than Lina's motorbike.

"Aunt, do you have any leftover fabric?"

She stopped the machine.

“What for?”

The truth was right there. A few words would have done it: for Maly's crutch.

“For school.”

“What assignment?”

My lie hadn't prepared for the next question.

“A... pillow project.”

“A pillow project?”

“To learn about shapes.”

Aunt Sophea looked at me for a long time. I think she knew I was making it up. Sometimes adults pretend to believe kids just to see how far the lie will go.

She opened a box and gave me a piece of blue fabric, clean and thick.

“Bring it back if your pillow doesn't need all of it.”

“Yes, Aunt. Thank you.”

The folded fabric in my bag felt much heavier than normal fabric.

Next, I went to Uncle Sarath's house. He was stacking pieces of wood under his house to clear out the upstairs room. The meeting on Monday was going to decide whether the school could move in there, but he was already getting the space ready.

“Do you need something?” he asked.

“A small scrap of clean foam. For a model.”

“What kind of model?”

“For school.”

I already hated those words.

Sarath dug through a box of supplies he kept out of the rain. He handed me a rectangle of foam wrapped in paper.

"This piece is clean. But if your model has to hold any weight, you show it to me first."

"It won't hold any weight."

That wasn't completely false. The crutch held Maly. The cover would only hold her shoulder. I used that difference to make myself feel like less of a liar.

On my way out, I found Vannak sitting on the fence.

"So?" he asked.

"So what?"

"Your pillow project."

"Were you spying?"

"You lie really loud. People can hear you from the road."

He took my notebook before I could stop him and looked at the blue plan.

"This is for Maly."

"Give it back."

He gave it back.

"Has she agreed?"

"It's a surprise."

"So, no."

"She's hurting, Vannak."

"I know."

"I'm not changing the crutch. I'm just making a cover that comes off."

"Then show it to her before you put it on."

"If I show her, she'll say no before she even tries it."

"Maybe she has the right to."

That made me angry, because it sounded too much like the truth.

"You always repeat your father's rules. At least I'm trying to do something."

Vannak jumped off the fence.

"Following the rules is doing something."

"Easy for you to say."

He took a step back.

"I'm not going to help you. And if you don't tell her tomorrow, I will."

He left without letting me have the last word, which should be against the rules between friends.

I waited until the afternoon. Mae had gone to help Lok Ta Bun's family. Maly was writing at her friend's house. Under our house, I laid out the fabric, the foam, and two old clean shoelaces.

My drawing was right in front of me. The real pieces wouldn't fit together so neatly.

I folded it, tried it, undid it, and started over. The first time, the fabric came open. The second time, it made a lump on one side. The third time, it almost looked like my drawing, if you looked from far away and were feeling very kind.

I put the cover on my forearm and pressed down against the ground. It was soft. It held.

I felt proud.

That evening, Maly told us she had written a new page. Mae talked about Lok Ta Bun. His wife was going to stay with him a while longer, and the families were taking turns watering his garden. I kept my bag against my foot.

“What’s in there?” Maly asked.

“Stuff.”

“What stuff?”

“My stuff.”

“You’re very interesting tonight.”

When everybody was asleep, I waited even longer. The lamp was off. The moon lit up the room just enough.

Maly’s crutch was lying next to her mat. The pink ribbon hung down toward the floor.

I took the cover out of my bag. I crouched down.

All I had to do was slide it over the top. Nothing permanent. Nothing that couldn’t be undone.

My fingers brushed the ribbon.

I remembered the hidden page, the promise, and what Vannak had said: maybe she has the right to.

I could have stopped.

I didn’t.

I put the cover on the crutch, then lay back down with my heart going too fast.

In my notebook, my blue plan was straight, neat, and silent.

Next to Maly, the real thing leaned a little to one side.



CHAPTER TEN

The Slipping Seam

Sunday, April 27, 2025



I woke Maly up before Mae.

“Maly. Come look.”

She opened one eye.

“The sun isn’t even awake.”

“I have something for you.”

That sentence worked. Maly sat up and reached for her crutch. Her hand found the blue fabric.

She froze.

“What is this?”

“A cover. So the wood won’t hurt your shoulder anymore.”

She touched the foam under the fabric. Her face didn’t look the way I had imagined. In my imagination, she shouted with joy. In real life, she mostly looked surprised.

“When did you put it on?”

“Last night.”

"While I was asleep?"

"I wanted to give you a present."

Maly looked at the crutch, then at me.

"Try it," I said. "If you don't like it, we'll take it off."

Mae was still asleep. We went down to the yard. The morning light was gray. A chicken was scratching near the center post.

Maly put the crutch under her arm. She took a step.

"Is it softer?"

"Wait."

Second step. Third.

On the fourth, the cover twisted around the wood.

The crutch slipped out from under her arm. Maly tipped sideways and grabbed the post with both hands. Her notebook, which she had set on the step, fell into the dirt.

I rushed over.

"Are you okay?"

"Don't touch me."

She pulled herself up on her own, leaning against the post. The crutch lay on the ground with the blue fabric all crooked.

"You didn't fall," I said.

I don't know why I said that. Maybe because I was scared. Maybe because I was already trying to make the failure smaller.

Maly stared at me.

"That's what you have to say?"

"I mean... you didn't get hurt."

"Because the post was there."



Mae appeared at the top of the stairs.

“What’s going on?”

Maly picked up her crutch. Before she handed it to Mae, she untied the pink ribbon. Her fingers were shaking, but the knot came loose.

“Sokha changed it while I was sleeping.”

“I didn’t change the wood,” I said. “It’s only a cover.”

Mae came down. She took the crutch and looked at the twisted fabric.

“Where did you get this?”

“Aunt Sophea.”

“Did she know what it was for?”

I didn’t answer.

“Sokha.”

“I told her it was for school.”

Mae closed her eyes for a second.

“And the foam?”

“Uncle Sarath.”

“Did he know?”

“Not exactly.”

“What does not exactly mean?”

“No.”

Maly was holding the ribbon in her fist.

“You hid something else too,” she said.

I thought of the brochure under my sleeping mat. My silence answered before I did.

“What?” Mae asked.

I went back upstairs to get it. The paper was wrinkled where I had folded it too many times. I gave it to Mae.

Maly read the title over her arm.

“How long have you had that?”

“Since Wednesday.”

“Neak Kru gave it to you?”

“Yes.”

“And you didn’t tell us.”

“Mae was tired. The trip costs time. I wanted to fix something myself first.”

Maly laughed once, without any happiness in it.

“Fix what? Me?”

“No. The crutch. The pain.”

“My pain belongs to me too.”

“I know.”

“You always say that afterward.”

She set the ribbon down on the step.

“My crutch isn’t one of your drawings. When you touch it, you’re touching the way I stand up, the way I walk, the way I fall or don’t fall.”

“I only wanted...”

“I know what you wanted.”

Her voice broke on the last word. She hated that, and she started again, louder.

“You fixed what you could see. You never asked me what I wanted.”

Mae sent me to get Uncle Sarath. He came with his tool bag, but he didn’t use anything from it. He just took off the cover, looked over the crutch, and made sure it hadn’t been damaged.

“The wood isn’t cut,” he said. “I don’t see any damage. But I’m not the person who can tell you if this crutch is right for you.”

"I need it to walk."

"I know. The cover comes off. You can have your crutch back just the way it was. Tomorrow, I'll call Neak Kru Lina so the health center can check the rest. She mentioned an assessment day."

He turned to me.

"Something that holds up in your hand can slip when it's carrying a whole body. That's why people test things, ask questions, and don't work alone."

He didn't yell. I wish he had.

Mae told me to take the fabric back to Aunt Sophea and confess my lie. I also had to apologize to Sarath for taking the foam without telling the truth.

"What about Maly?" I asked.

"You'll apologize to her. She'll decide what to do with it."

Maly went back upstairs with her dusty notebook.

I followed her to the bottom step.

"I'm sorry."

"Not now."

"But..."

"See? Even with your apology, you want to pick the time."

She went up.

A little later, she called me. Her notebook was open to the story about the girl and the bell.

"You can read this page."

One sentence said: Her brother built something wonderful and carried her all the way to school.

Maly picked up her pencil. She crossed out the whole sentence.

“Why?” I asked.
“Because it isn’t my story anymore.”
Underneath it, she wrote slowly:
The girl asked for what she needed.
Then she closed the notebook.
I sat alone with mine.
I wrote:

I wanted to help.

I crossed it out.
Underneath, I wrote:

I didn’t ask.

I couldn’t bring myself to cross out the second sentence.

CHAPTER ELEVEN

The Meeting Under the Tree

Monday, April 28, 2025



I had written a speech that was 27 lines long.

It explained why the school had to keep going, why Maly had to be able to get there, and why the adults had to fix the road. I had used my blue pen and underlined the important sentences.

The best one said: No child should be left behind.

Neak Kru Lina probably would have thought it was beautiful.

Maly was still only saying the words she absolutely had to.

“Pass the rice.”

“Move your foot.”

“That’s my notebook.”

We went to the meeting separately. Mae and Maly walked with Lok Yeay Chan. I followed Uncle Sarath with my speech squeezed in my pocket.

Under the big tree at the wat, about thirty adults sat in a circle. The kids were supposed to stay behind them, but nobody had really decided where behind ended. Vannak and I sat by the roots. Maly sat inside the circle with Mae. She had gotten there after us, stopping at the places she had circled on our map on New Year's Day. It was the first time in a long time that she had made it all the way to the wat. Nobody seemed to notice. I did.

The village chief began.

"Lok Ta Ming's family is coming back. We have to decide if the school goes on, where it goes, and how the children will get there while the path by the ditch stays closed."

Lok Ta Phirun raised his hand. He owned several fields and sometimes hired Mae to work on them.

"I'm not against the school," he said. "But three mornings is already a lot when the paddy walls need fixing and the rice needs sorting. Families make promises. Then the work is still there."

I had expected him to say school was useless. His real argument was harder to answer, because I could see Mae's hands.

A woman answered him.

"Our children already work. If they never go to class, what will they do later?"

"Later doesn't fill the water jar today," Phirun said.

Uncle Phearak, Vannak's father, stood up. His left sleeve was folded back.

"And not knowing how to read doesn't fill it either. We need a schedule that works, not no school at all."

Neak Kru Lina spoke next.

"My organization can promise three days a week for the next month. Not five. I can't promise any more than that today."

She said it simply. Nobody clapped. But the chief wrote down the three days exactly, and several adults nodded.

Uncle Sarath offered his family's house.

"I have to move my tools and my sacks of grain. The room isn't ready. The roof leaks in one corner. But we can use it for a month and see after that."

The chief asked, "And the walk there?"

Everyone started talking again. Some people suggested a cart. Others said nobody had enough gas. Someone wanted the kids to take a shorter trail. Vannak immediately whispered, "That one hasn't been checked."

The chief said no to the trail.

I touched the speech in my pocket. This was the moment. I was going to stand up, read all 27 lines, and make everyone understand what Maly needed.

Then I saw Maly.

She was holding her notebook closed on her lap. Her pink ribbon was still in her pocket, not tied to her crutch. She was watching the adults talk about how tired she got, about her leg, and about the road, without asking her a single question.

I took out my blue pen.

I went over and handed it to her.

"Why?" she asked.

"In case you want to write something. Or read something. Or nothing."

"What about your speech?"

She had seen the paper sticking out of my pocket.

I folded it into quarters.

“It talks too much.”

Maly took the pen.

The village chief was already calling on the next person when Mae raised her hand.

She didn’t stand up right away.

“On Mondays and Wednesdays, I work early,” she said. “Friday is often market day. If class starts later on Mondays and Wednesdays, my children can do their morning chores. On Fridays, another family can walk them, and I’ll take their turn on a different day.”

Lok Ta Phirun asked, “And the other families?”

“We write down the days and the names,” Mae answered. “We don’t wait for somebody to volunteer every morning.”

Her voice was shaking a little, but she kept going.

“For bags and the little ones, we can take turns with carts. Not to cross a closed area. For the long way around.”

The chief wrote down the idea.

Maly opened her notebook.

“I want to say something.”

The whole circle turned toward her. I think Maly regretted it for a second. She squeezed the pen, then read what she had just written.

“I don’t want to be carried like a sack. I also don’t want people to pretend the road is easy. I’m asking you to count the breaks with me. If you’re making a plan for kids, ask the kids how they walk.”



She stopped.

“That’s all.”

After that, the adults stopped calling her the little one and started asking her questions.

Where did she need to stop? At what time of day did the heat get to be too much? Could she ride in a cart? Did she want an adult to stay with her?

Maly didn’t have all the answers.

“I don’t know yet,” she said, twice.

Nobody held it against her.

When the chief closed his notebook, we didn’t have a school forever. We had a month.

The chief read out what had been decided. For one month, class would be held three days a week in Sarath’s house. The families would try taking turns. The adults

would only put roads on the map that had already been approved. After a month, they would meet again.

On the way home, Maly gave me back my pen.

“Thanks.”

“Do you forgive me?”

She sighed.

“You’re a slow learner.”

“That’s not an answer.”

“Exactly.”

She kept walking with Mae. The pink ribbon stayed in her pocket.

At home, I read my speech again. The sentences were neat and brave. They would also have taken up all the room.

I put it at the back of my notebook without tearing it up.

CHAPTER TWELVE

The Book of Steps

Wednesday, April 30, 2025



On my first map, I made up three paths.

The first one cut behind the mango trees. The second went along a little canal. The third went past an empty house and reached Sarath's place in half the time.

I was very proud.

Mr. Kosal looked at my drawing and put his finger right in the middle of it.

"Who checked these paths?"

"Nobody. But you can see them."

"A map doesn't prove anything is safe."

He took out a blank sheet of paper.

"We only draw roads people already use and that have been approved. You don't test anything. You don't go look at any place just to finish your drawing."

We were all together under Sarath's house: Lina, some parents, Mr. Kosal, Vannak, Maly, and me. The little kids

were coloring in buildings everybody knew. Uncle Sarath had cleared part of the room upstairs. His tools were still piled into a mountain in one corner.

I started my map over.

This time, the route looked like what it really was: long, crooked, and sometimes without any shade.

Vannak made the key.

A circle for water. A square for a house where you could ask for help. Two little lines for a place to sit. A big black X for closed paths, without drawing whatever might be behind them.

“Your X is huge,” I told him.

“That way even Rithy will see it.”

Rithy, who was sitting two meters away, threw an eraser at him.

One of the little kids put his pencil between the tamarind tree and Sarath’s house.

“If you draw a straight line here, it’s shorter.”

Before, I would have liked his idea. I might have added a blue arrow and made up a walking time.

“We don’t know if you can go that way,” I said. “So we don’t put it on the map.”

The little kid looked at me.

“But you drew three.”

Mr. Kosal coughed into his hand. Vannak became very interested in his eraser.

“Yes,” I said. “That’s why I’m starting over.”

The little kid erased his line. You could still see a faint mark in the paper.

“It’s not just a map,” Maly said. “A map stays where you put it. We have to walk.”

She wrote on the cover: **Book of Steps.**



Maly timed her walk with Sarath’s old phone. The screen was cracked in a star shape. We set off on the approved road with Mae. Maly decided where to stop. I just wrote down what she said.

First stop: after the tamarind tree, under Lok Yeay Chan’s awning.

Second: under Aunt Dara’s mango tree.

Third: before the sandy slope.

“My shoulder starts burning here,” she said at the third stop.

“Should I write it like that?”

“Yes.”

“Burning?”

“That’s the word.”

When we got back, we added the breaks to the map. Lina suggested moving one of them earlier.

“Why?” Maly asked.

“So you can rest before it already hurts.”

Maly thought about it.

“We’ll try it Saturday.”

Not yes. Not no. We’ll try it.

While we were cleaning up, Vannak asked Mr. Kosal how a person gets onto his team.

“First, you finish school,” Mr. Kosal said. “Then you keep learning for a long time.”

Vannak nodded as if someone had just handed him a map.

“My father is going to love the first half,” he whispered to me.

After we finished, I took the blue fabric and the foam. Vannak was waiting for me outside Aunt Sophea’s house.

“You don’t have to come,” I said.

“If you’re going to lie again, I want to learn a new technique.”

Aunt Sophea was sewing the same yellow shirt, or maybe another one just like it. I handed her the folded fabric.

“There wasn’t any pillow,” I said.

She put her hands on her knees.

“I thought so.”

“It was for Maly’s crutch. I wanted to make a cover. I didn’t ask her. It slipped.”

"Is Maly all right?"

"Yes."

"And you? Did you learn something?"

Vannak coughed behind me.

"A little," I said.

Aunt Sophea took back the fabric.

"You can have good hands and still make a bad choice with them. Hands don't decide things all by themselves."

I looked at my hands. There was still blue ink on my finger.

At Sarath's house, I apologized the same way. He took back the foam, then showed me the almost empty room.

"Do you want to be useful?"

"Yes."

"Sweep. And this time, it really is for school."

I swept until the dust made a cloud big enough to make Vannak cough on the stairs.

At the end of the afternoon, Maly came to find me. Her crutch was back to its bare wood. The blue cover only existed now in my notebook and in the dust of the yard.

Maly took the pink ribbon out of her pocket.

"Can you hold the crutch?"

I held it without touching the top.

She tied the ribbon herself. The first knot was too loose. She did it again.

"On Saturday, you can come with us to the health center," she said.

"Really?"

"On one condition."

"What?"

“When the lady asks me a question, you don’t answer with your big mouth.”

Vannak laughed on the stairs.

“That’s a really hard condition for him.”

Maly closed the Book of Steps. On the cover, we had drawn the little bell, the well, and the winding road. Next to every break, there was now a name.

The road wasn’t any shorter.

But Maly no longer had to manage on her own.

PART FOUR

The Sound That Carries



Chapters 13–16

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

Measuring

Saturday, May 3, 2025



At the health center, the ceiling fan turned slower than a spoon in thick soup.

It squeaked on every turn.

Eeeek.

Pause.

Eeeek.

Pause.

After ten minutes, I knew the sound by heart. After twenty minutes, I wanted to climb on a chair and push the blades with my finger.

Mae guessed what I was thinking.

“Stay in your seat.”

“I didn’t do anything.”

“That’s to help you keep it that way.”

Maly smiled. She had leaned her crutch against the bench with the pink ribbon where everyone could see it. All

around us, kids were waiting with their families. A little boy was rolling a bottle cap under the chairs. A girl was wearing one red shoe and one blue shoe. By the door, a man held two metal crutches that shone through the dust.

The assessment day had brought in more people than Neak Kru Lina had expected. A poster, taped crooked on the wall, showed a road between our province and Battambang. I recognized the drawing from the brochure, but this time the brochure wasn't hidden under my mat. Mae had it folded in her bag.

We had left before the sun came up. Sarath had driven us, along with two other families, in the cart he hitches to the back of his motorbike. Every time we hit a hole, my teeth clacked together. Maly kept her lips pressed tight.

"Your shoulder?" I had asked once.

"It's still attached."

I figured out that I shouldn't ask at every hole.

A woman came out of the little room in the back. She wore a pale blue shirt and carried a clipboard.

"Maly?"

I stood up at the same time as my sister.

Mae gave me a look.

"I know," I whispered. "My big mouth stays shut."

The woman's name was Ms. Sreyneang. She had a soft voice, but not the extra soft voice some adults use with Maly, as if she were three years old or as if every word might break her.

She brought us inside. There was a table, two stools, a green curtain, and a box full of straps, rubber tips, and other things I didn't know the names of. I looked at them

without touching. I had already learned enough with my hands.

Ms. Sreyneang set her clipboard on the table.

“Hello, Maly. May I watch how you use your crutch?”

Maly nodded.

“You can tell me in words,” Ms. Sreyneang added. “Yes or no is perfectly fine.”

“Yes.”

She didn’t ask Mae. She didn’t ask me.

Maly took a few steps around the room. Ms. Sreyneang watched, then asked where it hurt. Maly pointed to the top of her shoulder, her palm, and the side of her hip.

“Since when?”

“My shoulder, for a long time. My hand, mostly when the road is hot and hard.”

“When the road is hot?”

“When I go fast,” Maly corrected herself. “I’m the one who gets hot. The road stays the same.”

Ms. Sreyneang smiled and wrote something down.

“And what would you like to be able to do more easily?”

I knew the answer.

Go to school.

I opened my mouth.

Maly’s eyes slid over to me.

I closed it.

Ms. Sreyneang waited.

Maly took her time to think.

“I want to get to the new classroom without hurting too much to write when I get there. And I want to be able to play at break. Not just sit down the second I arrive.”

I had known half of the answer. Not the other half.

"That's a good place to start," Ms. Sreyneang said.

She measured the height of the crutch. She asked permission before touching Maly's shoulder, then her hand. When she wanted to look at the bottom of the crutch, Maly untied the pink ribbon herself and set it on the table.

Ms. Sreyneang pointed to a crack in the rubber tip.

"This tip is worn out. And the crutch is a little too tall. That can put more pressure right here."

She pointed to the spot that kept turning red.

Ms. Sreyneang didn't cut the crutch or rig anything up right there. She chose an adjustable crutch from her supplies, checked the height, changed the tip, and asked Maly to try it. She showed her where to put her hand and made sure nothing rubbed under her arm.

Maly crossed the room once.

Then again.

The new metal made a little click with every step. Maly stopped in front of the green curtain.

"It's shorter."

"Is it better, or just different?" Ms. Sreyneang asked.

Maly walked across the room again.

"Better here," she said, touching her shoulder. "Weird in my hand."

Ms. Sreyneang adjusted the handle. Maly tried again.

The little click started up again.

I watched her foot, her crutch, her shoulder, her face. I wanted to decide based on all of that. To say: this one's good, we'll take it.

But it wasn't my hand on the handle.



“What do you think?” Ms. Sreyneang asked Maly.

“I want to try it on the path outside.”

They went out together. The ground in front of the center wasn't flat. There was hard dirt, a few stones, and a little slope down to a mango tree. Ms. Sreyneang walked next to Maly without pulling her. Mae followed them. So did I, two steps behind.

At the mango tree, Maly sat down on a root.

“It slips less. My shoulder still pulls.”

“That won't go away in one morning,” Ms. Sreyneang said. “We can adjust what can be adjusted today. For the rest, you'll need a fuller assessment and maybe several appointments.”

She explained that Maly could receive care at the center in Battambang, along with any mobility aids found suitable for her, free of charge. But the trip would have to be arranged. There might be measurements, fittings, and return visits. Nobody could promise that one trip would be enough.

Mae took out the brochure.

“What if we can't afford to make the trip more than once?”

Ms. Sreyneang wrote down the name of our village.

“Neak Kru Lina told me about your situation. We'll look with her and the center at what we can group together. I can't promise you transportation today.”

Mae folded the brochure carefully. Her face wasn't relieved, and it wasn't closed either. It was busy counting workdays, kilometers, and bowls of rice.

“Do I have to decide now?” Maly asked.

“No. Today, you only have to decide what you want to try.”

Ms. Sreyneang offered to let her keep the adjusted crutch for a few weeks, with a checkup appointment. They would talk about Battambang again later. She didn’t promise anything about the future. She talked about trying things, making adjustments, and the choices Maly could make at every step.

Maly looked at her old wooden crutch against the wall. Her pink ribbon was still on the table.

“I’ll take this one to try,” she said. “And I want the appointment. I don’t know about the rest yet.”

“That’s a complete answer,” Ms. Sreyneang said.

Maly picked up the ribbon. She tried to tie it to the metal tube, but it kept slipping. She tried again. The knot came out crooked.

“Do you want me to...”

I stopped before I finished.

Maly pulled on both ends.

“You can hold the bottom.”

I held the bottom.

Not the handle. Not her arm. Not the ribbon.

Just the bottom.

On the ride home, Sarath drove slowly. The sun came through the slats of the cart and painted stripes on our legs. Maly kept the new crutch lying against her so it wouldn’t fall.

“So?” asked Vannak, who was waiting for us by the well.

“So what?”

“Is it magic?”

Maly planted it in the dirt and took three steps.

The metal clicked. Her shoulder didn't stop existing. The road didn't get shorter. Battambang was still far away.

But her hand didn't slip anymore.

Maly looked at Vannak.

"No. It's not magic."

She took one more step.

"It's better."

CHAPTER FOURTEEN

Sarath's House

Monday, May 5, 2025



Sarath's house smelled like sawdust, machine oil, and old rain.

I don't know how old rain can have a smell, but this one had stayed inside the walls. When we opened all the windows, it went out with the dust.

This morning, we had to move the big school things from Lok Ta Ming's house. The books, the notebooks, and the cups would stay there until the last class. There were two mats, a blackboard, a box of chalk, a bucket, three cracked slates, and the little bicycle bell.

There were almost as many volunteers as there were things to carry. Chhun wanted to carry all three slates, because three slates looked more serious than one. After ten steps, he gave them all to me. Rithy had tried to roll up a mat by himself, and it had come unrolled three times in the dirt. Aunt Sophea tightened the ties around the mats,

then checked the knots twice without saying anything about mine.

For a few minutes, our move looked like a parade.

"We're missing the music," Vannak said.

Maly tapped her new crutch on the ground twice.

Click. Click.

"There."

Mae handed out the loads and reminded everyone that nobody was to leave the approved road, not even to catch a runaway cup. The parade kept its music, but it got some rules.

Neak Kru Lina had wrapped the bell in Mae's krama.

"It's not going to break," I said.

"Maybe not. But it could get lost."

"You can always hear a bell."

"Not when it's under a wheel."

I stopped arguing.

The blackboard was going to ride on Sarath's handcart. We followed on foot along the approved path. Sarath and two men pushed whenever the wheels sank; Mae and the other adults carried the light things; and each of us kids had been given a specific job.

Vannak carried the bucket, which made him look like a street vendor with nothing to sell. I carried the three slates against my stomach. Maly had chosen the box of chalk, which she carried in a little bag across her body so it wouldn't get in the way of her crutch.

"Is it too heavy?" I asked.

"No."

I waited three minutes.

“How about now?”

“If you ask me every three steps, your voice is going to get too heavy.”

I focused on my slates.

The long way started at the well, ran past the palm trees, went by Lok Yeay Chan's house, and came back to the main road. At the place where the old path would have cut straight across, we could see the rope and the signs in the tall grass.

Nobody went near them.

The sun climbed fast. The cart moved at the speed of a tired buffalo, even though there was no buffalo pulling it. At the first break we had marked in the Book of Steps, we set everything down under Lok Yeay Chan's awning. She had put out a jar of water and a ladle for us.

“If I'd known school was this heavy,” Vannak said, “I would've learned less.”

Neak Kru Lina handed him a cup.

“You can leave behind everything that's already in your head.”

“Then the bucket will still be heavy.”

Even Maly laughed.

At the second break, nobody was laughing anymore. The heat glued our shirts to our backs. One of the men sat down on the edge of the cart.

“For just the stuff, we could take the old path,” he said. “The kids wouldn't have to walk on it. We'd push the cart straight through.”

I looked at the blackboard tied down with rope. Then at the closed path, which was so much shorter.

He hadn't said the kids should go that way. Only the cart and two adults. For one second, my brain made a quick picture: the blackboard already in the classroom, the mats rolled out, everyone in the shade before noon.

Then I heard the noise by the ditch inside my head.

I put my slates down on the ground.

"No."

The man wiped his forehead.

"You'll stay right here."

"Mr. Kosal said that path is closed to everybody."

"The cart would only touch the tracks."

"We don't know what it would touch."

My voice was shaking, which made me mad. I wished I had Neak Kru Lina's voice, or even Mae's voice when she announces that there are no more mangoes. All I had was mine.

Vannak set the bucket down next to my slates.

"If the blackboard goes that way, I'm never looking at it again," he said.

"That's not how blackboards work," I muttered.

"I'm doing what I can."

Rithy dropped his mat next to the bucket.

"Mr. Kosal said a ball can be replaced," he grumbled. "A blackboard is just a big flat ball."

It wasn't an apology. But that day, he didn't call me a baby one single time.

Sarath came over to the man by the wheel.

"We promised the safe road," he said. "Not the safe road only when it isn't too hot."

He took off his krama, soaked it in the water jar, and put it back around his neck.

“We’ll keep going in ten minutes.”

The man looked down the long road, then drank. I couldn’t even be properly mad at him. I was hot too, and I wanted to be there already too.

We started again.

The left wheel got stuck in a rut. We had to unload the blackboard, carry it to solid ground, and then go back for everything else. A string snapped. The bucket rolled into somebody’s yard, and a chicken tried to climb into it.

By the time we finally reached Sarath’s house, the sun was almost straight overhead.

The classroom was upstairs. Sarath had moved his tools to the back and nailed up a wall of woven mats to separate them. That left one big open room with three windows. From one, you could see the approved road. From another, the top of the mango tree.

Maly climbed the stairs slowly. The new crutch clicked on every step.

Click.

Rest.

Click.

Sarath waited behind her without pushing. Mae went up ahead with the bag of chalk. I was stuck at the bottom with the slates, forced to be patient because the stairs were too narrow to pass anyone.

When she got into the room, Maly walked all the way around the walls.

“The mat goes here,” Neak Kru Lina suggested.

She was pointing at the corner farthest from the stairs.

Maly tried walking there from the door. Some tools stacked against a partition made the path narrow.

“There, I’d have to turn twice,” she said. “If we put it by this window, I can go straight.”

Sarath moved the tools.

We rolled out the first mat by the window.

“What about the blackboard?” I asked.

“Not too high,” Vannak said. “Sokha still has a lot to learn.”

“So do you.”

“But I’m tall in my head.”

Neak Kru Lina gave each of us a rag.

We scrubbed the blackboard until the water at the bottom of the bucket turned black. Maly put the chalk in a low box she could reach from the mat. Then she picked the spot for the bell: on the post by the doorway, at the height of her hand.

Sarath fastened the little bell with a strong clamp. He tugged on it, made sure it didn’t move, and stepped back.



“Try it.”

Maly reached out.

“No,” Neak Kru Lina said.

Everybody looked at her.

“Not yet. The first ring is for the opening.”

Maly let her arm drop.

The bell stayed quiet.

We had planned to open the classroom on Thursday. But there was still the roof to check, the walk to do again with the families, and the benches to carry over. Sarath looked at our dusty faces.

“Friday,” he decided. “Thursday, we finish without rushing.”

I wanted to argue. A whole extra day had just landed in front of my impatience.

Then I thought about the cart, the shortcut, and the wheel stuck in the rut.

“Friday,” I repeated.

Before we left, I unfolded Mae’s krama. I had forgotten the bell had been wrapped in it. In the middle of the cloth, a little ring of black dust marked where it had been.

Maly ran her finger over the bell’s rusty lever.

The bell moved the tiniest bit.

A very small sound slipped out.

Not a real ring.

More like the beginning of a voice that was waiting for Friday.

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

Rain Before the Bell

Wednesday, May 7, 2025



The rain came during dictation.

At first, a single drop hit the palm leaves above us.

Then another one.

Neak Kru Lina looked up.

“Put your notebooks away.”

The whole sky fell down.

We were still in Lok Ta Ming’s old room for our very last class there. In a few seconds, the rain came through three holes in the roof. The kids crowded into the corner that was still dry. Mae, who had come to help pack up the books, put basins under the leaks.

The noise was so loud that Neak Kru Lina had to shout.

“NOT THAT ONE!”

Vannak, who was carrying a stack of notebooks, stopped.

“WHAT?”

“THE DRY BOX!”

“I CAN’T HEAR ANYTHING!”

He put the notebooks in the wet box.

We managed to save them before the water soaked through the cardboard, but the corners curled up. Mine too. The chicken mark on my first page now looks like a little wave.

Maly had tucked her own notebook under her shirt. She was protecting the cover with one hand and holding her crutch with the other.

“Give it to me,” I said. “I can put it in the plastic bag with mine.”

She hesitated.

Her notebook was the thing she had told me not to touch since the very beginning.

A raindrop rolled down her nose.

She handed it to me, closed.

“You keep it dry.”

“I won’t open it.”

“I know.”

I slid both notebooks into the bag and tied three knots. The third one probably didn’t do anything, but it made me feel better.

The rain stopped as suddenly as it had started. Outside, the whole village was shining. Water dripped from the roofs, the chickens shook out their feathers, and the dry ground drank so fast that a thin steam rose up next to the houses.

The adults went out to see how far the cart could go the next day. We kids waited with Lina.



Mr. Kosal had been very clear: after a heavy rain, nobody was allowed to leave the known paths or go near any marked boundaries. So Sarath, Mae, and two other adults set out on the approved road, without touching anything off to the sides. Neak Kru Lina kept us under Lok Yeay Chan's awning.

Waiting is a very long activity.

Vannak floated a leaf in a puddle. Two little kids built it a dam out of mud. Maly and I watched the road.

"Your notebook is dry," I said.

"You already told me."

"I just wanted to..."

"I know."

She laid her new crutch across her knees. The pink ribbon was wet at the end and had turned darker.

"Do you think we'll open on Friday?" I asked.

"Are you asking because you want my answer, or because you want me to say yes?"

I thought about it.

"A little of both."

"Me too."

The adults came back with mud up to their ankles. According to them, the cart couldn't get through the low part of the road until the water went down. The ground had washed away along the edge. On foot, the walk was still possible on the known track, but we would have to go slowly and check it again the next day.

Neak Kru Lina looked at the books that were still stacked up.

"We can push back the opening."

The words push back fell into the middle of us like an overripe mango.

"For how long?" I asked.

"Until we can move the rest of the things safely."

Mae wrung out her krama.

"Or the classroom opens with what's already there. The children don't need everything on the first day."

"We still have to carry the last notebooks and the cups," Neak Kru Lina said. "And tomorrow, we need to make sure the walking path holds."

"Maly can stay home on Friday," Mae added. "Just for the first day. When the road is dry..."

Maly pressed her lips together.

Every face turned toward Maly. Mine too.

I had an answer ready. I could say that Maly had promised to read. That the bell shouldn't ring without her. That we could carry her. That Sarath could find another cart. I had four ideas before Mae even finished her sentence.

I let them bump around inside my head.

Then I asked, "Maly, what do you think we should do?"

She studied me as if she were looking for a trap.

"Are you really asking me?"

"Yes."

Maly pulled the Book of Steps closer. The rain had stained the cover, but the pages inside were dry.

"Tomorrow, the adults check the road again," she said. "If it's okay to walk on, we don't send the stuff and the kids together. The adults carry the supplies in small bags. We keep only our own things, in a shoulder bag or backpack."

She turned a page.

"On Friday, we don't all leave at the same time. The fast kids go ahead with Neak Kru Lina. The ones who need breaks come with Mae and Sarath."

"The ones who need breaks?" Vannak asked.

"You, if you keep talking."

He accepted that with a nod.

Maly put her finger on the houses we had drawn.

"We keep the break at Lok Yeay Chan's. Then another one under Aunt Dara's mango tree. We'll need water at both places. I don't want anybody carrying me unless I ask."

Mae crouched down next to her.

"The ground will be heavy. Your shoulder might hurt too much by the time you get there."

"Then I'll leave earlier."

"And if it starts raining again?"

"We come back the same way. Or we stay at Lok Yeay Chan's. That's why we need an adult with us."

Mae looked for another hole in the plan. So did I, out of habit. Maly waited.

"It's a trial," Mae said. "If Sarath and Mr. Kosal say the road is all right tomorrow. If the sky holds. And if you say you want to stop, we stop."

"Even if we're late?"

"Even if we're late."

Neak Kru Lina picked up the notebook.

"We still need someone to carry water."

Vannak sighed.

"I knew the bucket would find me."

We made a clean copy of the plan. Maly talked; I drew. A drop from the roof landed on the blue road. The ink ran, but you could still read the line. I added only one thing without asking: a chicken next to the first break.

“Why a chicken?” Maly asked.

“So we can recognize the house.”

“Every house has chickens.”

“Then our map is very accurate.”

She took the pencil and drew a gigantic beak on my bird.

Neak Kru Lina asked how we would let the families know who weren't there. I turned to a new page. This time, I didn't pick the title.

“Write For Friday,” Maly said.

I wrote it.

“The adults check the road on Thursday. If it's still approved, there will be one group that leaves early and one group with breaks. Everyone carries a small bag. Nobody leaves the known path. If it rains again, we wait.”

I read the message back to her.

“You forgot the water.”

I added the two houses where the water jars would be ready.

“And you wrote slow group.”

“It's shorter.”

“That's not its name.”

I crossed out **slow** and wrote **with breaks**. Every parent who was there took a copy to a house on their way home. Maly kept the original in the Book of Steps.

That evening, she asked for her notebook back.

I gave her the bag with my three knots. The last one was so tight she had to use her teeth.

“Did you open it?”

“No.”

“Not even the last page?”

“No.”

She checked the cover, then the inside. A tiny drop had reached the edge of one page without touching the writing.

“On Friday, where are you going to walk?” she asked.

“With you.”

“That’s not a place.”

I looked at the map.

“Next to you. Not in front.”

“Good.”

“Thank you,” she said.

The thank you was so small that the rain could have covered it up. I heard it anyway.

I liked it better that way.

CHAPTER SIXTEEN

The Road to the Bell

Friday, May 9, 2025



On the morning of the opening, the sky was clean. Not empty. Not blue everywhere. Big clouds were waiting behind the palm trees, but they were barely moving.

Mae watched them for a long time.

“Maybe they’ll let us through.”

Maly was ready before I was. She was wearing a new yellow shirt: the one I had seen twice under Aunt Sophea’s sewing machine. I had never once thought to ask who it was for. She had tied back her hair with a strip of blue cloth. The pink ribbon was knotted on her new crutch. Her notebook was in a waterproof bag, with the page she was going to read marked by a piece of thread.

I was still looking for my other sandal.

“Under the mat,” Maly said.

“Why would it be under the mat?”

“Because you threw it at the chicken yesterday.”

I found it under the mat.

We were supposed to meet Mae and our small group by the well, where the road began. The fastest kids had already left with Neak Kru Lina. They were carrying only their water bottles and their notebooks. The last of the books had gone over the day before in little bags carried by the adults, after Sarath and Mr. Kosal had checked the known road.

That left our group: Maly, two younger kids, Vannak, Mae, Sarath, and me.

Vannak was holding the bucket.

“It’s empty,” he pointed out.

“We can see that,” I said.

“I want history to remember that, for once, nobody gave me the heaviest thing.”

Lok Yeay Chan’s house was just past the first bend. From far away, I could see that nobody was waiting for us under the awning. The water jar was there, covered, but Lok Yeay Chan wasn’t.

Sarath went up to the steps and called out. Her granddaughter answered from inside. Lok Yeay Chan had left before dawn to visit her sick sister. She had left the water, but she couldn’t be there for the break like we had planned.

Mae frowned.

“We needed an adult here in case someone had to wait or turn back.”

The first hole had just appeared in our beautiful plan.

“Are we canceling?” one of the little kids asked.

His lip trembled.

"No," Sarath said. "I'll stay here for a while, in case someone needs to turn back or comes along late. Then I'll catch up with you."

"And if someone turns back?"

"I'll walk them home. Mae keeps going with the others."

Maly sat down on the low step. She drank two sips of water, no more. I watched her face.

"What?" she asked.

"Nothing."

"You're looking at me the way Ms. Sreyneang looked at the crack in the tip of my old crutch."

"I just wanted to know if..."

"Ask."

"Do you want to keep going now, or wait a little longer?"

Maly rolled her shoulder.

"Five more minutes."

I set down my bag.

The fast kids were probably already in the new classroom. Maybe they had rolled out the mats. Maybe Neak Kru Lina was writing the date on the board. Maybe someone was looking at the bell and wondering why we weren't there yet.

I almost said: hurry up.

Instead, I counted five minutes by watching a line of ants carry away a dead beetle. They were moving faster than we were. They were also much more numerous, and they didn't have to go to school.

"Now," Maly said.

We set off again.

The wet dirt stuck to our soles. Where the rain had washed away the edge, we stayed in single file on the part the adults had marked. Sarath had stayed behind at the break. Mae led the way. Maly walked between her and me.

When the path widened, I moved back beside Maly.

Not to pull her along. To walk with her.

The crutch sank in a little with every step.

Click into the dirt.

One step.

Click.

One step.

Halfway to Aunt Dara's mango tree, Maly stopped.

The second break was still far away, maybe three houses' worth. She had already walked this part on moving day. In the Book of Steps, we had even written: possible without stopping.

But this morning, the ground was pushing back harder.

"My shoulder's burning," she said.

Mae looked at the mango tree.

"You can lean on me until we get to the shade."

Maly shook her head.

"I'm stopping here."

There was no bench, no mat. Only the dry edge of the road and a tree stump in somebody's yard.

Vannak turned the bucket upside down. Maly sat on it.

"So it was useful after all," I said.

"I always knew it would be."

Mae gently rubbed Maly's shoulder after asking her if she could. A little kid started drawing squares in the mud with a stick.



I listened to the quiet up ahead.

“Class is going to start,” I said.

Maly looked down at her fingers wrapped around the handle.

“Yes.”

“We could still...”

I didn’t finish.

“I don’t want to be carried,” she said. “Not now.”

“Okay.”

“If we get there late, we get there late.”

“Okay.”

It didn’t feel okay at all. Opening day was supposed to be perfect. We were supposed to show up on time, clean, with the sun behind us. Maly was supposed to walk all the way to

the door without hurting, read without shaking, and ring the bell in one smooth move.

But that day only existed inside my head.

The real day had mud in it, an upside-down bucket, and a shoulder that burned.

We waited.

When Maly stood up, she didn't say the pain was gone.

"It went down a little," she said.

We reached the mango tree. Aunt Dara had tied a water bottle to the trunk for us. She was already out working in her field, but a note was tucked under the string: Drink. Close the cap.

Vannak read the first word all by himself.

"Drink," he announced.

"We know," I said.

"I was reading."

So we let him read the other three too.

After the second break, the road sloped gently up toward Sarath's house. The new classroom appeared between the trees. The windows were open. A row of sandals lined the bottom of the stairs.

And nobody was having class.

The kids were sitting on the mats, but the blackboard was still empty. Neak Kru Lina was waiting by the entrance. The little bell shone on its post.

"You didn't start?" I asked from the bottom of the stairs.

"We put our things away, answered three riddles, and kept a gecko from falling into the chalk box," Neak Kru Lina said. "But no. We didn't start."

Maly put her crutch on the first step.

She climbed the stairs.

Click.

One foot.

Click.

One foot.

I came up behind her with her bag, because she had asked me to at the bottom of the stairs. At the top, she turned around to make sure the two little kids were coming too.

Neak Kru Lina pointed to the bell.

“It’s waiting for you.”

Maly set her bag down by the mat and took out her notebook. Her hands were shaking a little. I didn’t know if it was from the walk, from everybody looking at her, or both.

“First, I’m going to read,” she decided.

Everyone sat down.

Even the adults stayed to listen, standing near the door. Sarath had finally caught up with us. He was breathing hard, but he claimed it was because of the stairs.

Maly opened her notebook to the page marked by the thread.

She started too quietly.

“Louder!” Vannak whispered, loud enough for everyone to hear.

Maly gave him a look. Then she started again.

“Once upon a time, there was a girl who wanted to go to a house full of words. The house wasn’t very far away, except for her arms. Her brother always said, I’m going to save you. So the girl told him, save the fish that fell out of your basket instead.”

Laughter ran across the mats.

I looked at Vannak.

“I have never lost a fish.”

“Not yet,” he whispered.

Maly kept going.

“The girl asked for a road with breaks and friends who listened. She also asked for a bell, because she liked the sound it made. The people made mistakes. The rain ruined their plan, and the bucket arrived empty. So they started over. Everyone carried what they could, and the girl carried her story.”

She stopped to turn the page.

There wasn’t another one.

“Is that the end?” asked the littlest boy.

“For today,” Maly answered.

She closed the notebook.

Neak Kru Lina went to the board and wrote:

Friday, May 9, 2025

And underneath:

First Day in Our New Classroom

“Three days a week for one month,” she reminded us. “After that, the families and the kids will say what’s working and what needs to change.”

By the door, Lok Ta Phirun was already talking to Mae about the next days in the rice fields. Sarath was reminding

the chief that his house was only available for a month. Neak Kru Lina had circled the date of the next meeting on her calendar. In Mae's bag, the Battambang brochure was still waiting for a trip.

None of that had gone away.

But this morning existed.

Maly stood in front of the little bell.

She raised her hand.

Her fingers slipped on the lever. The bell made a muffled sound.

Tlk.

Nobody laughed.

Maly took hold of the lever again and pushed it hard.

Brrring!

The sound filled the room, jumped out the windows, and ran down the stairs. Sarath's chickens scattered across the yard. This time, all of us laughed.

I had imagined a big bell that people would hear all the way out in the fields. This one fit under my sister's hand. Its ring probably didn't go any farther than the mango tree.

But it found everybody anyway.

Twice.



EPILOGUE

A Page in Two Voices

Sunday, May 11, 2025



Today, the rain is keeping us at home. It's falling gently, without attacking the roof. Mae is sorting beans under the house. Every bad bean bounces into a dish with a little tock. Maly is sitting on the bottom step. Her crutch is resting next to her, and the pink ribbon is almost dry.

I'm trying to finish this notebook.

There's only one page left.

The first page got eaten by a chicken. The ones after that collected dust, sweat, a raindrop, and a thumbprint from the day I touched charcoal. One page still has the word help crossed out so hard you can read it from the other side.

I could write the end of the story.

Maly got to school.

Maly read.

Maly rang the bell.

Those sentences are true. But mostly they tell what I saw.
I hold the notebook out to my sister.

"You write the last page."

She looks at my hand, then at the notebook.

"It's yours."

"I know."

"You're giving me the ending?"

"I'm giving you half."

"Which half?"

"The half I don't know."

Maly takes the notebook. She turns the pages slowly. She stops at the drawing of the ball, the market list, and the map of the road. When she gets to the cover that slipped, she looks up at me.

"You really wrote all of this?"

"Almost all of it."

"You wrote that you lied to Aunt Sophea?"

"Yes."

"Good."

She gets comfortable on the step. I give her my pencil.

"No," she says. "The blue one."

I take the pen from the market out of the notebook's pocket. The one I lent her at the meeting, the one she gave back on the way home. She blows on the tip as if she could wake up the ink.

"You're not allowed to look until I'm done."

"It's my notebook."

Maly doesn't say anything.

I go downstairs to help Mae sort beans.

After five minutes, I look up.

Maly hides the page with her arm.

After ten minutes, I look up again.

"Sokha!"

"I was looking at the rain."

"The rain isn't on my lap."

Mae gives me an extra handful of beans to keep me busy.

Finally, Maly calls, "You can come now."

The blue ink covers a little more than half the page. Some of the letters go uphill, and some go downhill. Two words are crossed out. Maly reads it herself.

"My shoulder still hurts. The road is still too long when it rains. On Friday, I had to sit on Vannak's bucket, and he's probably going to talk about it until he's an old man."

"That's true," I say.

"Don't interrupt."

I close my mouth.

"I have an appointment in Battambang, but we don't know yet how we're going to get there. I'm a little scared. I don't know if I'll want an artificial leg or something else. First I'll ask what it's for and if I can try it."

"Next year, for the New Year, I'm going to the wat. Sokha says he'll find a way. This time, I'm the one who will tell him which way."

I recognize my promise from the very first day, the one that almost went through three pages. I don't say anything.

She runs her finger under the next line.

"I didn't walk like before, because I don't know what before means. I walked like me. I got there late. I read my story. I rang the bell twice, because the first time almost didn't count. I want to do it again."

Maly puts down the pen.

“That’s my half.”

She keeps one finger on the page.

“Tomorrow, I’m going to ask Neak Kru Lina to make a copy for Lok Ta Bun.”

“Of the whole page?”

“Yes. His wife can read it to him if he wants.”

“Do you think he’ll write back?”

“I don’t know. I just want him to know the bell rang.”

I read it again quietly. I stop at I walked like me.

“Is it good?” she asks.

“Yes.”

“Just good?”

“It’s really good.”

“I like that better.”

She leaves me the bottom of the page. There’s room for three lines, four if I write small.

I pick up my pencil.

I write:

Next time, I’ll ask first.

I think about it, then I add in parentheses:

*(Even if my idea is brilliant. Especially if my
idea is brilliant.)*

Maly reads over my shoulder.

“Your ideas aren’t that brilliant.”

“Then it’ll be easy.”

She takes back the blue pen. At the very bottom, in the last white corner, she draws a tiny bell. The circle is lop-sided. The lever looks like a mouse’s tail.

Maly draws two little lines around it.



Brrring. Brrring.

Then she blows on the ink so it won't smear.

Words from the Village



Khmer New Year (Chaul Chnam Thmey): the Cambodian New Year, celebrated for three days in the middle of April.

Bong: a way of speaking to someone older than you. Here, it is what Maly calls her big brother.

Mae: Mom.

Krama: a traditional Cambodian scarf with many uses, like keeping off the sun or carrying small things.

Neak Kru: a respectful way to address a female teacher.

Lok Ta, Lok Yeay: respectful ways of addressing an older man and an older woman.

Wat: a Buddhist temple and monastery, often at the heart of village life.

Neak Ta: a guardian spirit connected to a particular place.

Num banh chok: rice noodles served with a fragrant herb sauce, often made with fish.

Riel: the money used in Cambodia.

Kuy teav: rice noodle soup.

A Note on the Story



Chhouk Ksant is a made-up village, placed for the purposes of this novel in the Cambodian province of Banteay Meanchey. The story of Sokha and Maly is invented, but the difficulty of getting to school, the land mines and other explosives left behind by decades of war, and the work of rehabilitation services are all inspired by real life today. The border provinces of the northwest, including Banteay Meanchey, still hold much of the land in Cambodia that has yet to be cleared of mines. Lina's class, the people providing support, and the May 3 assessment day are fictional. The rehabilitation center in Battambang is real; care and transportation arrangements should be checked directly with the relevant services.

In real life, a marked area or a suspicious object must never be approached or touched. Stay far away and tell an adult or the proper authorities right away. A crutch, an artificial leg, or any other mobility aid should always be chosen and adjusted together with the person who uses it, with help from trained professionals.

MY CORNER OF THE WORLD

My Corner of the World follows four fictional young narrators in four countries on three continents. Each book can be read on its own, and they speak to each other in surprising ways.

Sokha's Diary: The Road to the Bell

The Drum and the Ball: Lamine's Journal

Ananya's Notebook: The Stolen Flame

Anastasiya's Echo: Katya's Notebook

